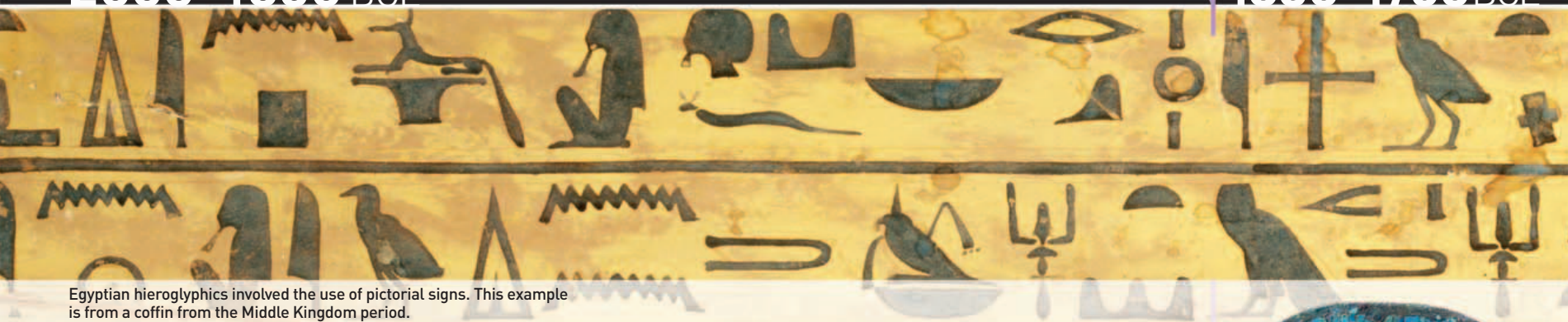




Egyptian hieroglyphics involved the use of pictorial signs. This example is from a coffin from the Middle Kingdom period.

THE MINOAN CIVILIZATION, named after the legendary King Minos, **flourished** on the **Aegean island of Crete** in the early 2nd millennium, reaching its peak between 2000 and 1600 BCE. It is thought that Crete's **prosperity** was based on the **export of pottery, gold, and bronze**, as well as possibly grain, wine, and oil, to Egypt, Cyprus, and Palestine. The Minoans established colonies in many parts of the Aegean, including the islands of Kythera, Thera, Melos, and Rhodes, and at Miletos on the Turkish mainland.

The farmlands of Crete were ruled from cities with **central palaces** that housed workshops,

the administration, religious facilities, and state storerooms. Those at Knossos, Phaestos, Mallia, and Zakros were particularly impressive, judging by their remains. Around 1700 BCE, these palaces were burned down, and only **Knossos** was **rebuilt**, on a more magnificent scale than before, suggesting its dominance over the entire island. The palace was five stories high, with rooms opening onto inner courtyards. This mazelike complex is thought to have given rise to the labyrinth in the **legend** of the **Minotaur**, a bull-headed monster.

Bulls certainly featured in Minoan ceremonies. The **deities**

worshipped in Minoan shrines seem to have been **female**, with a **goddess of nature** being the most popular. However, details of Minoan culture remain obscure, since the Minoan scripts, known as Cretan hieroglyphic and Linear A, have yet to be deciphered.

In Egypt, King Mentuhotep had reunited the country at the end of the 3rd millennium (see 2350–2000 BCE). Yet the second of Egypt's eras of strong, centralized rule only **began with** the reign of **Amenemhet I**, from about 1985 BCE, during the Middle Kingdom. In 1965 BCE, his successor **Senwosret I** conquered the land of **Nubia** to the south,

40

THE NUMBER
OF DAYS IT
TOOK TO
MUMMIFY
A BODY

extending Egypt's borders as far as the second cataract of the Nile. Nubia yielded gold, copper, and slaves to swell the ranks of Egypt's army. Around a century later, **Senwosret III** also made **Levant** a vassal state of Egypt.

Middle-Kingdom Egypt was **more democratic** than it was during the Old Kingdom period. Rulers presented themselves as shepherds of the state rather than absolute monarchs. The process of **mummification**, once confined to kings, was now **permitted for ordinary citizens**. In order to preserve it as a permanent home for the spirit, the body was dried in natron salt, its vital organs were removed, and it was stuffed with linen and wrapped in bandages.

Charging bull

Minoan rituals included a bull-leaping ceremony, in which athletes grasped the bull's horns and vaulted over its back. This Knossos fresco dates back to c. 1500 BCE.



Shang bronze

This bronze plate was found at Erlitou, and is of the Xia period. It is inlaid with turquoise mosaic, believed to represent a dragon's scales.

IN CHINA, THE SHANG

CIVILIZATION developed along the **Yellow River** by 1850 BCE. According to legend, China's first dynasty was the Xia, but current archaeological evidence points to **Shang** as the **first dynasty**. At Erlitou in Henan province, archaeologists have uncovered a **palace complex** built on a

20,000
THE NUMBER
OF CLAY
TABLETS SO
FAR FOUND
AT MARI



c. 2000 BCE City of Ashur becomes dominant in northern Mesopotamia

c. 2000–1750 BCE Arctic Small Tools population, ancestors of the Inuit, spread from Alaska across Canada to settle Greenland

c. 1985–1955 BCE King Amenemhet I brings stability to Egypt during Middle Kingdom period

c. 1965–1920 BCE Reign of Senwosret I of Egypt

c. 1900 BCE City of Erlitou constructed around Yellow River, China

1813–1781 BCE Reign of Shamshi-Adad; conquers northern Mesopotamia to establish Kingdom of Upper Mesopotamia, with its capital at Shubat-Enlil

c. 2000 BCE Corn, beans, and squash cultivated in southwestern North America; long-distance trade routes in place

c. 2000–1600 BCE Minoan civilization of Crete reaches height

c. 1984 BCE Founding of first dynasty of Babylon

1960 BCE Senwosret I of Egypt defeats Nubia and extends his kingdom as far as second cataract on Nile

c. 1900 BCE Towns and small kingdoms developing in Anatolia

c. 1900–1700 BCE Indus civilization declines; cities gradually abandoned